

Feminist Consciousness and Gender Negotiation in Nollywood: A Comparative Study of *Lionheart* and *King of Boys*

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Abstract

*This study explored the emergence and articulation of feminist consciousness in Nollywood, Nigeria's prolific film industry. As a dominant cultural force across Africa, Nollywood plays a significant role in shaping societal perceptions of gender roles, identities and power relations. While feminist themes such as women's empowerment, resistance to patriarchy and gender based inequality have increasingly appeared in contemporary Nigerian cinema, the depth and consistency of these portrayals remain uncertain. This study sought to highlight Nollywood as a potential platform for advancing gender equality and reshaping public consciousness around women's roles in Nigerian society. Grounded in feminist film theory and African feminist theory, the research evaluated both the ideological support of gender representation in Nollywood and the audience's reception of feminist messages. Using a qualitative content analysis of selected Nollywood films namely: *King of Boys* 2018 and *Lion Heart* 2018 this study examined how feminist ideals are represented in narrative structure, character development and thematic expressions. It also investigated whether these portrayals challenge traditional gender norms or merely reproduce them under modern guises. The findings of this work point out the rise in the number of female filmmakers, directors and scriptwriters in Nollywood, also there has been a significant shift from traditional gender roles to more empowered female characters. This research recommended filmmakers to be intentional in telling stories that challenge patriarchal norms and portray women as intelligent, independent and empowered individuals instead of narratives that overly victimize women or define them solely in relation to men. This study contributed to knowledge by inspiring emerging filmmakers to approach storytelling through a gender-sensitive mindset.*

Keywords: Feminism, Power, Agency, Consciousness

Introduction

The Nigerian film industry has emerged as a powerful medium of communication and cultural expression. As the second-largest film industry in the world by volume (Okome, 2004). Nollywood plays a crucial role both reflecting societal realities and shaping public discourse in Nigeria and across the African continent. It serves as a mirror of Nigerian life also influencing the ways in which citizens interpret and engage with social, political and cultural issues. Nollywood films often reflect the social conditions, beliefs and moral values prevalent within Nigerian society. The themes such as corruption, family conflict, gender roles and religious

tensions are commonly portrayed serving as a cultural archive of contemporary Nigerian life (Haynes, 2011). The frequent dramatization of everyday challenges allows audiences to see their realities mirrored on screen thereby reinforcing shared cultural narratives. Beyond reflection, Nollywood actively shapes public opinion through storytelling, the industry promotes new ideas, challenges traditional norms and raises awareness of critical issues such as domestic violence, electoral malpractice and youth unemployment (Jedlowski, 2013). As such, Nollywood can be viewed as a site of ideological production where meanings are negotiated and contested. Films increasingly feature progressive narratives that promote gender equality and question patriarchal values contributing to changing societal attitudes (Akudinobi, 2020). Nollywood has also become a platform for marginalized groups including women, ethnic minorities and youth. With the rise of independent filmmakers and digital distribution platforms, more diverse stories are being told. These narratives not only provide visibility to underrepresented communities but also contribute to national conversations on identity, inclusion and social justice (Larkin, 2008). Nollywood exerts considerable influence on public behavior including fashion, speech and lifestyle choices. More importantly, it also plays a role in civic education. For instance, some films are produced in collaboration with NGOs or governmental agencies to promote awareness about health crises, electoral participation and human rights (Obiaya, 2015). In this way, Nollywood contributes to nation-building and democratic engagement. Nollywood is not just merely an entertainment industry, it is a powerful cultural institution that both mirrors and molds public discourse in Nigeria. By reflecting societal concerns and shaping the narratives around them, Nollywood contributes to the ongoing dialogue about what Nigeria is and what it aspires to become.

The Nigerian film industry, Nollywood has witnessed a gradual but significant transformation in the representation of women over the past three decades. Early Nollywood films largely portrayed women as submissive, passive and dependent on male characters. However, contemporary production now depicts women in more dynamic, strong, autonomous and leadership roles reflecting broader societal transformations and growing gender awareness. During the formative years of Nollywood (1990s – early 2000s), majority of female characters existed in relation to male protagonists. These characters often reinforced patriarchal norms and moralistic narratives. Women were portrayed as either virtuous wives, dangerous seductresses or supernatural threats (Okome, 2007). For instance, the movie *Living in Bondage* (1992), one of Nollywood's pioneering films depicted women primarily as temptresses and sacrificial victims. By the mid-2000s, the industry began shifting its narratives focus, driven partly by the emergence of female directors, writers and producers such as Mildred Okwo, Emem Isong and ChinnyLove Eze. These filmmakers gave more opportunities to female actors thereby saving them from sexual harassment and introduced more nuanced and empowered female characters. Films like *The Figurine* (2009) and *The Meeting* (2012) started to reflect the complexity of women's experiences in Nigerian society (Ugochukwu, 2014). In its early years, Nollywood heavily relied on gender stereotypes especially in the portrayal of women. These depictions were often rooted in traditional norms and moral expectation, framing women as submissive wives, emotional manipulator, seductresses or supernatural threats (Okome, 2007). Such roles reinforced a patriarchal value, suggesting that a woman's virtue was tied to her obedience, beauty or domestic ability. A reoccurring stereotype was the “wicked stepmother” or the “materialistic girlfriend”, often portrayed as greedy, dangerous and destructive. Films such as *Domtilla* (1996) and *Glamour Girls* (1994) presented women who stepped out traditional roles

as morally corrupt or doomed. The implication was that independence or ambition led to social or spiritual ruin (Haynes, 2011). These portrayals served a didactic purpose thereby warning women against disobedience, independence or challenging male authority. The frequent use of the “evil woman” trope including the witch, homewrecker or jezebel reflected societal anxieties about female autonomy (Ugochukwu, 2014).

In recent years, Nollywood has increasingly embraced counter stereotypes portrayals that challenge and subvert traditional gender norms. These representations include women as leaders, entrepreneurs, politicians and moral agents, actively shaping their destinies. For instance, *King of Boys* (2018) by Kemi Adetiba features a powerful female protagonist, Eniloa Salami who is both a political force and a complex character navigating ambition, motherhood and corruption. Unlike earlier films that punished female power, *King of Boys* allows its heroine to maintain agency without being reduced to a moral lesson (Okafor, 2018). Similarly, *Lionheart* (2018) directed by Genevieve Nnaji, rejects the notion that leadership is inherently masculine. The protagonist, Adaeze leads her father's business with competence and grace, challenging the stereotype that women are not fit for positions of power. These counter-narratives are also supported by the growing presence of female writers, producers and directors who bring diverse perspectives and lived experiences into storytelling (Haynes, 2011). Nollywood's evolution from stereotype-heavy portrayals to more balanced and diverse representations of women reflects broader cultural and ideological shifts. While stereotypes still persist in some genres especially in romantic comedies and traditional epics, the rise of counter-stereotypes signals progress. The industry's growing commitment to telling women's stories with depth, nuance and authenticity marks a significant departure from its early depictions and continues to influence gender perceptions across Africa and the diaspora.

Kemi Adetiba's *King of Boys* (2018) and Genevieve Nnaji's *Lionheart* (2018) holds significant relevance in feminist discourse due to their female authorship, iconic status and global visibility. As films directed by women in a historically male-dominated Nollywood industry, they challenge gendered power structures behind the camera and foreground female creative agency. *King of Boys* subverts patriarchal norms by centering a morally complex, authoritative female protagonist who navigate and dominates political and criminal spheres traditionally reserved for men. In contrast, *Lionheart* presents a more subtle form of empowerment through its portrayal of a competent professional woman who assumes business leadership within cultural constraints. Together, these films expand representations of African womanhood, diversify narratives of female power and demonstrate the global resonance of women-led storytelling through their international distribution, including major platforms like Netflix. Their impact ultimately underscores evolving feminist possibilities in contemporary African cinema.

Statement of Problem

Although academics recognize changes in Nollywood's portrayal of women, important issues still need to be addressed. Numerous studies paint a conflicting image, showing that the business creates both strong, independent female characters and regressive, moralizing depictions that reinforce patriarchal standards (Okome, 2007; Haynes, 2016). Existing literature frequently catalogues representational trends or highlights increasing female participation behind the camera, but relatively few studies systematically examine how feminist ideologies are constructed at the level of cinematic form (mise-en-scène, framing, editing, narrative structure)

and how those formal choices interact with culturally specific feminist logics such as negotiation, collective agency and maternal authority. Furthermore, research frequently views "women's representation" as a singular phenomena without giving enough consideration to the variety of feminist stances (liberal, radical, African/nego-feminism) that may be present in movies (Nfah-Abbenyi, 1997; Tamale, 2020). As a result, this study tackles two issues: first, it is necessary to determine whether and how Nollywood stories actually reflect feminist consciousness rather than merely using feminist terminology for profit; second, it is necessary to identify the cinematic processes by which feminist meanings are generated and limited in the Nigerian setting.

Aim of the Study

This study sets out to examine feminist consciousness and gender negotiation in *King of Boys* and *Lionheart*.

Research Questions

1. How do the selected movies embody feminist consciousness?
2. In what way do these films reflect gender negotiation and nego-feminism?

Contribution to Knowledge

Firstly, this topic enriches feminist theory by examining how African cultural products particularly Nigerian films reflect and challenge gender norms.

Second, this study shows that Nollywood is a potent medium for influencing social perceptions of gender roles, equality, and women's empowerment in addition to being a source of enjoyment. This realization highlights how crucial media is to shaping societal change.

Thirdly, this study can inspire emerging filmmakers to approach storytelling through a gender-sensitive lens, ultimately contributing to a more inclusive and socially aware Nollywood.

Finally, this topic uncovers structural barriers facing women in Nigerian film industry such as underrepresentation in technical and leadership roles, gender bias in casting and the lack of institutional support for feminist content. It provides a basis for future policy reforms and advocacy.

Methodology

This study used a qualitative research design to evaluate how feminist consciousness was portrayed in a few Nigerian movies. This method is taken into consideration because the study aimed to investigate gender dynamics and power in Nigeria. In a similar vein, the researcher was able to closely investigate the topics, language, and character development of a few chosen films thanks to this qualitative method. The portrayal of female characters and gender dynamics, which reflect the larger society background, can be thoroughly and interpretively analyzed using a qualitative technique. The study's main goal was to comprehend the feminist consciousness in Nigeria's film industry as it is portrayed in a few Nollywood productions, with a focus on how these aspects affect or subvert social norms and expectations. The ability of qualitative research to offer deep insights into the meanings, themes, and symbolism ingrained in the movies is why it was selected. The study investigated the narratives of the characters,

cinematic devices, and how these components interact to convey messages about gender roles and societal expectations through meticulous film analysis. Purposive sampling was used in this investigation. For qualitative research, purposeful sampling works best when the researcher looks for specific traits in the sample that are pertinent to the study's goals. In this instance, the movies were chosen because they depicted strong female characters negotiating social expectations and were pertinent to the topics of feminism and gender issues.

Both primary and secondary sources of data were used in this investigation. The two movies that were selected for the study were used as primary data, and their feminist themes were examined. On the other hand, secondary data will come from written or printed sources, including books, media reports, online resources, magazines, research reports, journal articles, and more. These secondary sources offer background for interpreting the results of the film analysis as well as a theoretical framework for comprehending how gender and cultural identity are portrayed in the movies. Recurrent themes, symbols, and patterns pertaining to feminism and gender roles were found using the source data. This was improved by the secondary data, which provided important viewpoints, theories, and frameworks that deepened the investigation. Both descriptive and thematic analysis were used to analyze the data. While thematic analysis concentrated on discovering and understanding important feminist themes, descriptive analysis involved summarizing each movie's fundamental components, such as the storyline, primary characters, and setting. The process of thematic analysis entails organizing the data based on recurrent themes, such as the objectification of female characters, gender stereotypes, cultural expectations, and female characters' identity problems. African feminist theory and feminist film theory served as a guide for the analysis, which helped to place the representation of female characters into larger social, political, and cultural settings. A framework for comprehending how female characters are portrayed and how much they defy or adhere to conventional gender stereotypes was offered by feminist film theory. On the other hand, African feminist theory assisted in examining how individual interests and compromise improve harmonious cohabitation in the society depicted in the movies.

Theoretical Framework

This study was guided by Feminist Film Theory and African Feminist Film Theory.

Feminist Film Theory emerged in the late 1960s and 1970s as part of the broader feminist movement that sought to challenge the patriarchal structures prevalent in various fields, including media and cinema. Credit goes to Laura Mulvey, a British film theorist and feminist as the proponent of the theory. Mulvey's groundbreaking essay, *Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema*, published in 1975, is considered one of the foundational texts of Feminist Film Theory. In this essay, Mulvey introduced the concept of the "male gaze," which argues that traditional Hollywood cinema is structured to appeal to heterosexual male viewers by objectifying women and positioning them as passive subjects within the narrative (Mulvey, 1975). This feminist film theory provides a station for the appraisal of how films perpetuate or resist traditional gender roles. Thus, examining the representation of women in film and the ways in which these representations contribute to the construction of social norms surrounding gender. Feminist Film Theory explores the intersection of gender, power, and narrative within cinema, interrogating how women are often objectified and how male dominance is reinforced through cinematic techniques. The Feminist Film Theory has experienced different levels of development since its inception. As a matter of fact, throughout its progressive stages, the theory

has been closely associated with several key concepts. The male gaze operates through three distinct perspectives: the gaze of the camera, the gaze of the characters within the film and the gaze of the spectator. These combined reinforce the objectification of women and limit representations of female experience. Feminist scholars have since expanded upon or critiqued Mulvey's theory to account for race, queer identities and more complex spectatorial positions.

Mulvey identifies two primary forms of visual pleasure as Scopophilic pleasure and Narcissistic identification. Scopophilic is a psychoanalytic term used in describing the pleasure derived from looking at others as objects of erotic contemplation. Drawing from Freud, Mulvey argues that cinema naturally lends itself to Voyeuristic pleasure allowing spectators to observe characters especially women without being seen themselves. This kind of pleasure therefore is not just a form of visual enjoyment but is culturally organised to reinforce gender power relations. Through close-up shots, body positioning and stylised display, mainstream cinema eroticises the female body, inviting the spectator to take pleasure in looking while simultaneously upholding a masculine viewing position. Thus, for Mulvey, scopophilia is central to understanding how filmic representation sustains and naturalises patriarchal ideologies (Mulvey 1975). Narcissistic identification refers to the pleasure a spectator experiences by identifying with an on-screen figure, typically the active protagonist. Drawing from Lacanian psychoanalysis, Mulvey argues that cinema acts like a “mirror” that offers the spectator an idealized version of themselves similar to Lacanian mirror stage where individuals first form a sense of self by identifying with an external image.

Also, this analysis fits perfectly into the concept of “Female Gaze” by E.A. Kaplan who proposed it as a way for women to assert subjectivity, agency and alternative ways of seeing on screen. In Nollywood, filmmakers have increasingly incorporated the female gaze to challenge traditional gender norms and present women as active agents rather than passive objects a concept that is contrary to Mulvey's male gaze. This concept allows female characters to inhabit their own desires, ambitions and moral perspectives. Nollywood film such as *King of Boys* employ female gaze by presenting Eniola Salami as a powerful independent and resilient woman rather than defining her solely in relation to a male character. Through framing, camera angles and narrative focus, the film invites audience to identify with Eniola's perspectives, emotional world and her decision-making processes. Such portrayals could enhance more empowering and authentic representations, encouraging audiences to see female characters as multifaceted individuals with complex aspirations, fears, and desires. This shift could be transformative for Nollywood, where traditional gender roles often limit female characters' narrative potential. Films like *Lionheart* (2018) and *King of Boys* (2018) exemplify this potential, depicting women as complex leaders who navigate social and professional hierarchies, thereby challenging conventional portrayals of gender in African cinema.

Bell Hook's concept of the oppositional gaze is a foundational intervention in film theory. Black feminist criticism and visual culture studies. In her seminal essay “Oppositional Gaze: Black Female Spectators.” Hooks (1992) argues that black women develop a distinct resistant way of looking that disrupts dominant cinematic representations. This gaze emerges from a historical context in which black people particularly black women were punished for looking, denied subjectivity and excluded or stereotyped in visual media. Hooks situates the oppositional gaze within the racialised politics of vision in the United States. Historically, enslaved Black people

were forbidden to look directly at those who held power, making looking itself as an act of resistance. In contemporary media, the gaze becomes a political site for challenging white supremacist visual regimes. Hooks (1992) argues that mainstream cinema has traditionally centered white subjectivity while marginalizing or misrepresenting blackness particularly black femininity. By cultivating a critical oppositional gaze, black viewers resist identification with dominant narratives and interrogate the radical hierarchies embedded in visual culture. The oppositional gaze is fundamentally an act of resistance. Rather than passively accepting the images presented in film, black women viewers engage critically, refusing the distortion of their experiences.

African Feminist Film Theory is a rich and evolving field that centers around African cultural, historical and political realities in the interpretation and production of cinema. Unlike Euro-American cinematic tradition, African film theory often emphasizes oral traditions, collective memory, decolonization and indigenous modes of storytelling (Diawara, 1992). Obioma Nnaemeka, a Nigerian scholar and feminist theorist, is the originator of the concept of Nego-Feminism which is the short for Negotiated feminism or no ego feminism. In her foundational 2004 essay, Nnaemeka (2004) introduced nego-feminism as a distinctly African feminist framework rooted in the cultural, social, and political realities of African women. Nego-feminism is characterized by negotiation, collaboration and community centeredness. It rejects adversarial approaches to gender struggles and emphasizes dialogue and compromise especially within family and societal structures. Rather than positioning feminism as oppositional or confrontational, Nnaemeka's approach recognizes that African women often achieve empowerment through subtle and strategic engagement with power systems, prioritizing family harmony and social cohesion alongside personal agency. Furthermore, nego-feminism is grounded in indigenous knowledge systems rejecting imposed Western feminist frameworks that may not align with African realities. It emphasizes "no ego", meaning that the feminist activism should not be driven by individualistic motives but by collective upliftment and practical outcomes. Through nego-feminism, Nnaemeka provides a contextually relevant, decolonized feminist theory that honors African women's lived experiences, moral economies and socio-cultural contexts.). Although the term "nego-feminism" was coined by Obioma Nnaemeka, Molara Ogundipe-Leslie significantly contributed to its intellectual foundation through her African-centered feminist philosophy. Ogundipe-Leslie's framework, especially her theory of STIWA - Social Transformation including Women in Africa provided a crucial basis for nego-feminism's emphasis on contextual, communal and negotiated approaches to gender equality (Ogundipe-Leslie, 1994). Ogundipe-Leslie rejected Western feminist universalism, advocating instead for a decolonized feminism rooted in African cultural and social realities. Her work emphasized negotiation rather than confrontation, family and community harmony and the importance of local agency which is the principles that are central to nego-feminism (Nnaemeka, 2004). She was among the first to insist that African women's liberation must be pursued within a collective and culturally grounded framework rather than solely through individualist or oppositional means. While she did not coin the term, Ogundipe-Leslie's intellectual and activist contributions helped shape the philosophical and ethical underpinning of nego-feminism, influencing how African feminists theorize agency, power and resistance.

Nego-feminism is highly relevant to the Nigerian cultural context as it reflects the realities,

traditions and social dynamics of Nigeria society. Rooted in the principles of negotiation and non-egotism, nego-feminism addresses the complexities of gender relations in Nigeria by emphasizing community, family cohesion, cultural respect and pragmatic resistance (Nnaemeka, 2004). In many Nigerian communities, especially among the Yoruba, Igbo and other ethnic groups, social harmony, respect for elders and communal values are central to everyday life. Rather than adopting confrontational strategies typical of some Western feminist models, Nigerian women have historically used subtle negotiation, relational diplomacy and indirect power to navigate patriarchal structures (Oyewumi, 1997). This makes nego-feminism a more culturally compatible and effective approach to advocacy for women's rights in Nigeria. Additionally, nego-feminism aligns with Nigerian indigenous practices, where womanhood is often tied to collective roles such as motherhood, kinship and spirituality. By promoting gender equity through dialogue rather than conflict, nego-feminism respects traditional roles while also pushing for transformative, making it a context-sensitive and socially sustainable feminist framework within Nigeria.

Radical feminism emerged prominently in the 1970s alongside second-wave feminism and the rise of feminist cultural criticism. Central to this tradition is the argument that mainstream cinema reproduces patriarchy by organising visual pleasure around male and female objectification (Mulvey, 1975). From this perspective, cinema is not a neutral medium but an ideological apparatus that normalises women's subordination. Radical feminist filmmakers and theorists therefore argue that feminist cinema cannot be achieved solely through "positive" female representation. Instead the cinematic apparatus itself which are the camera movement, editing, narrative structure and spectatorship must be interrogated and reconfigured. This position marks a clear departure from equality-based feminist approaches and frames cinema as a site of political struggle. One key cinematic strategy of radical feminism is the refusal of patriarchal narrative structures. Classical cinema typically relies on linear causality, individual agency and narrative closure often resolved through romance, marriage or reintegration into social norms. Radical feminism film resist these conventions by foregrounding repetition, stasis or unresolved endings. The disruption of the male gaze is one of the most influential radical feminist cinematic interventions. Another defining strategy of radical feminist cinema is its emphasis on embodied experience and material conditions. This focus on materiality aligns with radical feminism's insistence that women's oppression is structural rather than psychological or individual. The body is not a site of spectacle but of labor, discipline and control; reinforcing cinema's potential as a tool for feminist consciousness-raising.

In Nollywood, radical feminist paradigms are evident in films such as *King of Boys* that portray women who openly resist male authority, reject traditional gender roles and challenge cultural institutions such as marriage, inheritance system and religious authority. Such films often depict female protagonists who assert economic independence, confront abusive relationships or expose male hypocrisy. Narratives centered on women-led protests, refusal of polygamous arrangements or direct confrontation with sexist norms exemplify this paradigm. However, radical feminist representations in Nollywood are frequently framed as controversial or destabilising, sometimes resulting in narrative punishment toward the female character. This reflects broader societal discomfort with overt challenges to entrenched patriarchal norms. Despite their limited prevalence, radical feminist narratives are significant because they introduce counter-hegemonic discourses into popular culture. They question the inevitability of

male dominance and offer alternative visions of female agency, even when such visions are portrayed as socially disruptive.

In contrast, Nollywood frequently favors negotiated feminism, portraying women who achieve empowerment through dialogue, resilience and strategic accommodation. Female characters may challenge injustice while still valuing marriage, family cohesion and communal harmony. For example, women may negotiate respect within patriarchal households, use economic contribution to gain authority or mobilise collective female solidarity without rejecting cultural identity. This paradigm resonates strongly with Nollywood's audience because it aligns with indigenous values and lived realities. It avoids framing feminism as antagonistic to African culture instead presenting it as adaptive and relational. Consequently, negotiated feminism is often rewarded within narratives, with female protagonists achieving both personal fulfillment and social acceptance.

Conceptual Frameworks

Highlight on feminist agency in Nollywood cinema which refers to the ways in which Nigerian film represent women's capacity to act independently, resist patriarchal constraints and influence both narrative and cultural perceptions of gender. Nollywood has historically depicted women through stereotypical roles rooted in traditional patriarchal norms. However, recent scholarship highlight an emerging trend of films and filmmakers that negotiate, challenge and expand notions of female agency within the industry's narratives and production practices (Ilo, 2025; Worlu & Harcourt-White, 2025). Recent research identifies a growing number of Nollywood films and female auteurs who foreground women as active agents of change. Filmmakers such as Funke Akindele, Kemi Adetiba and others produce films that challenge traditional gender roles and position female characters as decision-makers and leaders. These films often depict themes of personal resilience, economic independence and relational autonomy, thereby contributing to a configuration of female subjectivity in Nigerian cinema (Ilo, 2025, Worlu & Harcourt-White, 2025; Olawuyi & Odesola, 2025). Beyond on-screen representation, feminist agency in Nollywood also encompasses women's involvement behind the camera. Scholarship highlight s that increased participation of women as directors, writers and producers is reshaping narrative conventions and offering nuanced portrayals of gender. Indigenous women filmmakers are breaking barriers in a male-dominated industry and creating space for more inclusive storytelling.

Feminist theory recognises multiple ways in which women and marginalised genders exercise agency under patriarchal systems. Among these, radical agency and negotiated agency are two significant modes of feminist expression that illustrate differing strategies of resistance, empowerment and survival. These modes are shaped by social location, cultural context and structural constraints and they reflect diverse feminist responses to power and oppression. Radical agency often manifests through collective political action, protest movement s and ideological resistance. It emphasizes structural change rather than reform and aligns closely with radical feminist and Marxist feminist thought. By foregrounding issues such as reproductive rights, sexual autonomy and institutionalised violence, radical agency exposes the systemic nature of women's oppression (Hooks, 2000). While radical agency has been instrumental in achieving legal and social reforms, critics argue that it may overlook the lived realities of women who cannot afford open resistance due to cultural, economic or political

constraints (Mohanty, 2003). In contrast, negotiated agency operates within existing social and cultural frameworks, seeking incremental change through adaptation, compromise and strategic conformity. Rather than rejecting patriarchal norms outright, women employing negotiated agency reinterpret and manipulate these norms to gain autonomy and influence (Mahmood, 2005). However, negotiated agency has been critiqued for potentially reinforcing patriarchal structures by working within them. Despite this, contemporary feminism increasingly acknowledges negotiated agency as a legitimate and context-sensitive mode of feminist expression.

Gender is widely understood not as fixed biological essence but as a socially constructed and performative category (Butler, 1990). Power similarly operates less through overt domination than through discourse, normalisation and spatial organization (Foucault, 1977). Narratives participate in these processes by structuring whose experiences are centered and whose are peripheral. As a result, storytelling becomes a key mechanism through which gendered power relations are reproduced or challenged. Narrative space refers to not only to physical settings but also to symbolic, psychological and discursive arenas within a text. Control over narrative space such as focalisation, voice and plot progression often mirrors broader power hierarchies. Traditional narratives have frequently privileged male perspectives, positioning male characters as agents while confining female characters to domestic, private or marginal spaces (de Lauretis, 1987). These spatial limitations reinforce gendered power by neutralising inequality within the story world. Gender, power and narrative space are deeply intertwined. Narrative do not simply reflect social power relations, they actively construct and negotiate them through spatial organisation and voice. Analysing narrative space from a gendered perspective reveals how power operates subtly within texts and highlights the potential of storytelling as a site of critique and transformation.

Synopsis of *King of Boys* (2018)

Alhaji Eniola Salami (Sola Sobowale) nicknamed the king of boys is a formidable businesswoman, a philanthropist and an underworld power broker based in Lagos. She is loved by many but feared by most. She leads a syndicate of gang-lords, collecting a cut from all deals in her territory. Driven by ambition, Salami aims to enter mainstream politics but as her political profile grows, her criminal past begins to jeopardize her future. A rival under-boss named Mekanaki (Reminisce) plans a coup to dethrone her, straining loyalty and alliances with her own camp. Following a robbery organized by Mekanaki and Odogwu Malay (Illbliss) which excluded Salami's share; betrayals, false charges and political manipulation ensues. Eniola is arrested and after being acquitted, becomes entangled in a deadly game of deception. Her daughter becomes a pawn in the political maneuvering and tragedy strikes when Kemi (Adesua Etomi-Wellington) is brutally murdered in public. This devastating loss spirals Eniola into mourning, guilt and desperation. Haunted by grief and internal conflict often depicted through interactions with a younger version of herself played, Salami eventually hands herself over to the police but Mekanaki burns down her prison cell and frames her for further crimes. In the end, Eniola flees to Brooklyn, continuing to run a criminal network from exile.

Feminist Consciousness in *King of Boys* (2018)

Alhaja Eniola Salami embodies feminist consciousness through her refusal to remain confined to domestic or symbolic female roles. Instead she occupies spaces traditionally reserved for

men. Her command over male subordinates and political elites illustrates what Butler (1990) describes as the performative nature of gender – power is enacted not biologically determined. However, Salami's feminism is not idealised. She operates within violent and corrupt systems, suggesting a realist feminist perspective that recognises survival as a political act. This aligns with African feminist discourse which often emphasizes negotiation and adaptability rather than outright rejection of patriarchal systems (Nnaemeka, 2004). *King of Boys* articulates a complex feminist consciousness that challenges patriarchal norms while acknowledging the constraints imposed by existing power structures. Through Alhaja Eniola Salami, the film asserts that women can occupy and redefine spaces of authority even within hostile systems. Rather than offering an imaginary feminist vision, the film presents power as negotiated, contested and deeply gendered, making it a significant contribution to feminist discourse in African cinema.



Plate 1: Alhaja Eniola Salami addressing her party members in a meeting.

Source: *Netflix*.

Photographer: Screenshot by Ejekwu Chioma (2025).



Plate 2: Kemi, Alhaja Eniola Salami's daughter gets threatened by one of her mother's opponents.

Source: *Netflix*.

Photographer: Screenshot by Ejekwu Chioma (2025)

Synopsis of *Lionheart* (2018)

Lionheart is a Nigerian drama that highlights themes of leadership, gender equality and family dynamics within the context of the country's business and the cultural landscape. The story follows Adaeze Obiagu (Genevieve Nnaji), a competent and ambitious woman who works as an executive at her family's transportation company, Lionheart Transport. When her father Chief Ernest Obiagu (Pete Edochie), the CEO falls seriously ill, Adaeze expects to take over the company's leadership. However, her father unexpectedly appoints her uncle, Godswill (Nkem Owoh) as the acting CEO. Adaeze must learn to collaborate with her unconventional uncle as they work together to save a company from financial ruin and prevent a hostile takeover by a rival businessman. Through strategic thinking, courage and teamwork, Adaeze proves her capabilities not only as a woman in a male-dominated industry but also as a visionary leader. Set in Southeastern Nigerian and featuring dialogues in English and Igbo, *Lionheart* offers a rich representation of Nigerian culture and corporate life.



Plate 3: Adaeze Obiagu through strategic thinking, courage and teamwork with her uncle, the company is saved from debt.

Source: *Netflix*.

Photographer: Screenshot by Ejekwu Chioma (2025).



Plate 4: Chief Ernest Obiagu in a board meeting with his daughter and business associates.

Source: *Netflix*.

Photographer: Screenshot by Ejekwu Chioma (2025).



Plate 5: A staff from the Lionheart company under interrogation concerning the company's debt.

Source: *Netflix*.

Photographer: Screenshot by Ejekwu Chioma (2025).

Gender Negotiation and Nego -Feminism in *Lionheart* (2018)

Adaeze Obiagu, the protagonist of *Lionheart* exemplifies nego-feminism through her leadership style. Although competent and prepared to lead her father's transport company, she faces resistance rooted in gender bias. Instead of challenging patriarchy aggressively, Adaeze negotiates her authority through patience, emotional intelligence and strategic alliance-building. Her collaboration with her uncle Godswill Obiagu despite his initial incompetence illustrates “no ego” principle of nego-feminism. Adaeze prioritises the survival of the company over personal recognition, using persuasion and compromise to achieve long-term goals. This approach aligns with Nnaemeka's (2004) assertion that African feminism seeks transformation without social rupture. The film also challenges rigid gender binaries by depicting men as potential allies rather than adversaries. Godswill's eventual support of Adaeze's leadership underscores the possibility of negotiated gender roles. Power in the film is not monothonic rather it is shared and redistributed through trust and mutual respect.

Comparative Analysis

Radical versus Negotiated Feminism

Despite the differences, radical feminism and nego-feminism share common goals. Both seek to expose and challenge gender inequality, resist male dominance and promote women's autonomy. Each framework recognises that patriarchy is socially constructed and therefore open to transformation. Additionally, both approaches value women's lived experiences as a foundation for feminist knowledge. Whether through radical consciousness-raising or negotiated dialogue, women's voices remain central to feminist implementation. The most significant divergence between radical feminism and nego-feminism lies in strategy and context. Radical feminism advocates direct opposition to patriarchal systems often framing men

as beneficiaries or agents of oppression. In contrast, nego-feminism views men as potential partners in renegotiating gender relations. Radical feminism prioritises systemic overhaul while nego-feminism focuses on incremental change. The former risks social alienation in conservative contexts whereas the latter may be criticised for accommodating patriarchy rather than dismantling it. These differences highlight the importance of situational relevance in feminist application.

Radical feminism has been particularly influential in Western contexts where individualism and right-based activism are culturally reinforced. Conversely, nego-feminism is especially relevant in African and Global South contexts, where social transformation often depends on negotiation within existing cultural frameworks. Rather than viewing these approaches as mutually exclusive, this comparison suggests that feminist implementation benefits from theoretical diversity. The effectiveness of any feminist strategy depends on cultural, political and historical condition. Radical and negotiated feminism represent distinct yet complementary approaches to gender liberation while radical feminism offers a powerful critique of structural patriarchy, nego-feminism provides a culturally grounded model of resistance through negotiation and collaboration. A comparative understanding of these frameworks underscores the need for flexible, context-sensitive feminist strategies capable of addressing diverse gendered realities.

Discussion

The evolving representation of women in Nollywood carries significant implication for the development of African feminist cinema. As one of the most influential film industries globally, Nollywood plays a critical role in shaping social norms, gender ideologies and cultural narratives across Nigeria and the African diaspora. When Nollywood films challenge patriarchal stereotypes and foreground women's agency, they contribute to a broader feminist discourse that aligns with African feminist thought which emphasizes cultural specificity, communal responsibility and resistance to both local and global systems of oppression (Nnaemeka, 2024). African feminist cinema unlike Western feminist film traditions often negotiates feminism within culturally grounded frameworks such as motherhood, community, spirituality and tradition. Nollywood's increasing engagement with complex female protagonists – women who resist gender-based violence, negotiate power within marriage or assert economic and political autonomy- signals a gradual shift toward a more inclusive cinematic language. This shift has the potential to normalise feminist consciousness among popular audiences particularly given Nollywood's accessibility and mass appeal (Haynes, 2016). However, the implications are not uniformly progressive. Commercial pressure within Nollywood often result in narrative contradictions, where feminist resistance is introduced but ultimately contained through moral punishment, marriage or reconciliation with patriarchal authority. Such narrative closures risk reinforcing the very gender hierarchies they initially appear to critique. For African feminist cinema to thrive within Nollywood, sustained commitment is required from filmmakers, producers and distributors to prioritise gender-sensitive storytelling over purely market-driven formulas (Okome, 2007).

Furthermore, the growing presence of female directors, screenwriters and producers in Nollywood has significant implications for authorship and representation. Women's participation behind the camera expands the possibilities for authentic feminist narratives and

challenges male-dominated modes of storytelling. This development aligns with African feminist calls for self-representation and narrative control, positioning cinema as both a cultural and political tool for social transformation (Ukadike, 2014). Finally, Nollywood occupies a pivotal space in the future of African feminist cinema. Its continued evolution offers opportunities to reimagine gender relations, amplify marginalised voices and contribute to feminist cultural production rooted in African realities. The extent to which Nollywood fulfills this potential will depend on its willingness to embrace feminist aesthetics and politics not as marginal themes but as central to its storytelling practices.

Conclusion

This study examined feminist consciousness and gender negotiation in Nollywood through a comparative analysis of *Lionheart* (2018) and *King of Boys* (2018) revealing the evolving representation of female agency within Nigerian cinema. Both films challenge patriarchal norms by positioning women in spaces traditionally dominated by men however, they do so through distinct ideological and narrative approaches. *Lionheart* presents a reformist feminist framework that emphasizes collaboration, emotional intelligence and ethical leadership, portraying gender negotiation as a gradual and inclusive process within existing social structures. In contrast, *King of Boys* adopts a radical feminist posture, depicting power acquisition as confrontational and often violent thereby highlighting the cost of female empowerment in a deeply patriarchal political system. Ultimately, this research contributes to feminist film discourse by illustrating how Nollywood reimagines gender relations through localised narratives that resonate with African socio-cultural realities. By foregrounding women's voices and experiences, *Lionheart* and *King of Boys* expand the cinematic conversation on gender negotiation, suggesting that feminist consciousness in Nigerian cinema is dynamic, contested and deeply embedded within the struggle for social transformation.

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